

Consulted Legion (Claude / Gemini / OpenAI / DeepSeek, High tier). 3-of-4 converged on a single craft fix with 8-9 confidence each:

Every described object does double duty — corp indictment + character metaphor in the SAME beat. The scenery carries theme. The narrator stops monologuing. Kyle stays silent and lethal. The teeth at the end are the ONE unbranded object in the chapter.

DeepSeek's adjacent move: strip Kyle's internal commentary almost entirely. Pure sensory POV. Augmented speed lives in the gaps between sentences.

My own twist: shorter paragraphs, single-sentence lines that punch, no parenthetical asides, no sword mythology, action propulsive. The book is a knife not a tapestry.

Bearing Teeth

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

I

The freight elevator had a Carrion Logistics LLC inspection sticker dated last week and a control panel that had not worked since 2218.

It went up at the speed it had decided on. The cage was steel grating. Concrete dust on the floor said somebody had moved a refrigerator. The ceiling LED was the wrong color and bathed everything in the institutional green of a hospital cafeteria at three in the morning.

The resident elevator did not exist anymore. There was a shaft and there were doors. One of the doors had a paper sign that said OUT OF SERVICE in three languages, none of them issued by anyone who had ever fixed an elevator.

The airshaft brought the building up the side of the cage. Camphor from the second. Burnt rice from the fifth, the same Thursday burnt rice since 2189. Pork bone and scallion and old oil from somewhere between four and seven.

Mrs. Chen's stall. The smell of the contract waiting for him at the top.

Kyle stepped off on the eighth.

Unit 802. A door painted white four times by four people who had each disagreed about what white was.

She opened on the second knock.

"Come in, Mr. Corbin."

She had been trying his name for the duration of the phone call. *Corbin* was as close as she had gotten and he was not going to correct her.

The front room had a folding chair, a low table, and a television last turned on the year before last. On top of it: clementines, envelopes, and a small

carved wooden frog. The frog had a chip out of its left back leg.

The husband sat in the corner.

A wicker chair. Two breaks in the cane, both wrapped in electrical tape. He held his weight off the broken places the way a man held his weight off a thing he had stopped expecting the use of. His jaw was wired. Four-point titanium. A Carrion field-clinic job. The kind of job a Carrion field clinic did when the patient was billed against the same Carrion property registry the field clinic operated out of, and the field clinic had the budget the Carrion property registry had decided to give it, which was not enough for plates.

"My husband's name is Liu," she said. "He was a cook. He was a very good cook."

Liu blinked at Kyle.

Kyle bowed. Liu's blink returned it.

The light fixture was a Pinnacle Civil house-brand bulb from a 2210 closeout sale. The Pinnacle Civil CEO had been indicted in 2217 for routing the firm's taxes through a shell he also ran. The bulb had been a discontinued line for nine years. Forty-six left in the world. Chen Wei-Lin had bought twelve. She was on her seventh.

Across the canyon, in the tower opposite, the eighth-floor balcony had laundry on it. Linen. The kind of linen a family aspired to. The tower had a Hyacinth Property Management sticker on the western face, peeling, the corner curled the way confidence curled when nobody had renewed it. Hyacinth had pulled out of residential management in 2218 to focus on luxury verticals. The sticker had been there since.

In a window two buildings over, a man was arguing with a ride-share AI. His shoulders said he had been losing for six minutes. Kyle wished him well.

"The men who came," Mrs. Chen said.

"Yes."

"There were six. The one I want is Tien."

She did not point at her husband. The husband was already pointed at.

"He hit my husband three times with the back of a wrench. The first on the side of the head. The second on the jaw. The third on the jaw also. After the third he was satisfied."

"Why."

"The license."

The Carrion stall license. Three thousand Φ a year. Twelve installments unless one was missed. Then one installment plus interest plus a man named Tien, the visit itemized on the invoice as *Compliance Verification*. Carrion reported it to investors as enforcement-margin revenue. The 2225 annual report had cited it as evidence of the federation's operational health.

The Chens' jaw was operational health.

"You were short this month."

"Eight hundred."

"Why."

"The cold snap. We ran the fryer harder. The gas bill cleared on the third. Tien came on the second."

The cold snap had been an Arcturus atmospheric-processor maintenance window scheduled for February and performed in March. Arcturus had announced the rescheduling in a press release nobody read. The Chens had paid for it in fryer gas. The corp that owned the atmospheric processors and the corp that issued the stall license were the same corp through three intermediaries that did not, on any public filing, agree to be the same corp. They were the same corp.

A curtain shifted in the back room.

A face appeared at the gap. Twelve. Maybe thirteen. Her father's jaw, before the wrench. Her mother's eyes.

Kyle did not look at her directly.

Mrs. Chen had not turned. She knew.

She pressed credits into his palm. A pink hair-elastic banded them. The chips were warm. Six hundred and forty Φ . Half the standing rate.

"I do not have all of it, Mr. Corbin."

"It is enough."

"I do not have all—"

"Mrs. Chen. It is enough."

Her hands stopped trembling, second knuckle of the index first, the rest in a half-second cascade. The relief did not reach her face. The face had not been issued any relief since March.

Upstairs, somebody played a Cantonese pop song from 2218. A streaming service had served it to the building at funerals for the four years it was a hit. The streaming service had been the algorithm of a corp that had since standardized its catalog. Half its tagged songs no longer played anywhere. This one did. The song was not for Liu Chen. Liu Chen was still alive.

It was on retainer.

"You will be careful, Mr. Corbin."

"I will be efficient."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

She bowed. He bowed. He left.

The elevator ride down was a Carrion Logistics LLC inspection sticker dated last week and a control panel that had not worked since 2218.

II

The bike was matte black under a tier-six awning that did half the work of keeping it dry.

Three plates magnetized to the underside of the rear cowl. He chose the one issued to a Carrion subcontractor in 2206 that had never been cancelled. The Gray Zone surveillance grid was Pinnacle Civic Vision hardware, forty years old, cast off when Pinnacle had moved its product line to the corporation district. A Carrion plate went where a Carrion plate had ever been. Carrion plates had been most places.

He rode south.

The freight ramps had not been maintained since the second tier rezoning. Arcturus had withdrawn from the residential market in 2218 to focus on higher-margin verticals, which meant the ramps did not have an owner, which meant they had not been resurfaced, which meant the patches were three decades old and did not match.

Each ramp dropped him eight stories.

By the third, the architecture stopped pretending. By the fifth, the rain was warm — upper-tier rain came from cloud, lower-tier rain had been through six tiers of Arcturus exhaust on the way down. He did not roll the visor up.

A VTOL crossed the gap forty stories above. Amber lights. Climbing toward the corporation roof-traffic stratum. Some board director was late to dinner. Forty stories below the board director, in a stairwell that smelled like ammonia, a child whose grandmother had died because Hyacinth had reclassified stairwells as common-area-not-habitable to dodge the lighting code was learning to read the dark.

The grandmother had been ninety-one.

The lighting code had been amended in committee.

The bike was running clean.

He parked a block out. He walked.

III

The loading dock sat where the eastern strut met tier-zero substrate and tier-zero substrate was just concrete.

The building was on the Arcturus property registry as *industrial — out of service — pending evaluation*. Arcturus had been pending evaluation on this building since 2218. The evaluation was cheaper than vacancy in the corp tax code and indistinguishable from vacancy in actual use.

A Carrion Logistics LLC gantry above the slip had MOVING WHAT MATTERS stenciled across it in a font that had outlasted three of the men standing under it.

Six bays. Two roller doors open. Amber sodium overheads from before LED was a word. Everything looked like a polaroid in a kitchen drawer.

A man at the corner of the alley was trying to sell stolen ramen to a stevedore who didn't want stolen ramen. They were still working it out.

Kyle came in through the front because surprise was free.

Six men. A card game on a crate. Pai gow with hand-marked tiles because somebody had spilled something on the cards a week ago and nobody had replaced them. Tien was winning. Tien was always winning. The others had figured this out and had agreed, quietly, to let him.

Two chrome-arm men leaned on a stack of dollies. Hydraulic Solutions ARM-9s, recalled in 2222 for an elbow flexor that locked at full extension under stress. Hydraulic Solutions had recalled them. Hydraulic Solutions also required certified ID at the service window. The two men did not have certified ID because the men's IDs were sitting in a Lotus Syndicate drawer as collateral on the financing for the arms. The corp that sold the arms and the corp that took the men's IDs ran on the same authentication protocol. This was not a coincidence. The recall was, in this small specific way, still alive on both arms.

One man at the table had subdermal thoracic plating ridged at the collar — low-end clinic, fast install, the kind of work the Helix subcontractors did after Helix had stopped inspecting them in 2222.

One had chrome knuckles. Nineteen. Cosmetic. Very fresh. Hydraulic Solutions consumer credit. If he survived the year, the arm would cost him three times the install price.

One had no visible work. Internal. Expensive. Decisions.

The last had a face rebuilt cheap and tight on the left side. The skin pulled the wrong way over the lower mandible. The parts of his face had run out somewhere along the line.

Tien.

The laughter died at the tempo laughter died when the math changed in a room. It died last in the chrome-knuckle kid. Nineteen. Hadn't learned the tempo.

The no-visible-work man set his tiles face down.

"You lost, friend?"

"Looking for Tien."

The man looked at Tien. Tien looked at the man. The man looked back at Kyle.

He had decided to make this take one more sentence than it needed to.

"Tien is occupied."

"He won't be."

The man's head tilted. The kid's hand moved toward his waistband, telegraphed at the shoulder a full half-second before the hand committed. The chrome-arms shifted a quarter inch each. The subdermal-plated man set his tiles down.

Tien sat very still.

The no-visible-work man had a katana inside his coat. Kyle had clocked the saya at the threshold by the way the fabric draped. A man carrying a sword at a Tuesday card game was a man expecting somebody.

He had been expecting Kyle.

Somebody had paid him to be here.

Kyle filed the somebody. Later.

"Kyle from down the street."

The man smiled.

Chorus came out of the holster in Kyle's left hand.

Crack — crack-crack-crack.

Buckshot at the kid's right knee. The joint separated. He went down sideways.

Slug at the subdermal man's left knee. His fighting philosophy had ended at his chest. The kneecap had not been consulted.

Slug at the near chrome-arm's right knee. The hydraulics did not load-bear on the leg. The leg was flesh.

Slug at Tien's left knee. At an angle that would loosen teeth.

The far chrome-arm had started his swing in the half-second between the first shot and the second. The arm came around at the height where Kyle's collarbone had been.

Kyle stepped under it.

The katana cleared the saya. Right hand over the right shoulder. One motion.

He put the edge into the shoulder seam.

Tink.

The arm finished its swing into empty air without its owner. The motor bus was severed.

The elbow flexor locked at full extension.

Hydraulic Solutions had recalled it in 2222. The man had never brought it in. The arm went stiff at his side like a man hailing a cab.

Three seconds. Four shots. One cut. Five men down.

The no-visible-work man stood up.

He had not drawn during the count. He stood the way a man stood when he had watched his crew dismantle on schedule and had decided it was now his turn.

The hand went to his hip. The blade came out at the right angle in the right tempo. The guard settled into a stance from no school Kyle could name.

The man knew his work.

"Sloppy entrance."

He said it like a teacher correcting homework. The Korean inflected through the English of someone who had paid for the English along with the swordwork.

Kyle did not answer.

They closed.

The first exchange tested the line. A short cut, no commitment. *Tang*. Steel on concrete. The man read his information and stepped back.

The second exchange Kyle pressed. Cut high right. The man deflected, slid the edge past his shoulder. Smart. Conservative.

The third exchange the man committed. Cut high left, fast, clean, no telegraph. Kyle's parry was a fraction late. The follow-through opened three inches of Kyle's left forearm. Vein not artery.

The man saw the blood. He decided he was better than the man this was supposed to be. He had paid the kind of money you paid to decide that. The decision had been part of the asset.

The fourth exchange was the thrust.

Straight. Committed. Full extension. Line clean.

Kyle did not meet it at the edge.

He met it at the seppa. The thrust locked. He drove forward. He let the edge ride along the flat of the man's blade. The edge tracked from tip to middle to tsuba.

The edge met the wrist.

Bone. Tendon. The radial and ulnar. The median nerve.

The wrist and the sword fell together.

Clang.

The man looked at his wrist. He looked at his sword. He looked at Kyle.

"Oh."

The brachial did most of the work. Nineteen seconds.

Twenty-three for the duel. Twenty-six for the floor.

Kyle's hands were steady. They would shake in four minutes.

He sheathed the blade. A thin line of red near the kissaki. He wiped it on the man's coat. Chorus went back into the holster. Four chambers spent. One slug left.

The face on the floor was 71% Korean. The hardware filed it. The trail upstream ran through a Helix procurement officer in Seoul, through a NeoCortex steering committee, through three more committees, and out the top of a building in Geneva where the people who had signed the budget line did not, individually, know they had signed for a swordsman. Their budget lines did not specify swords. The Geneva committee would not learn what the lesson was. The Helix procurement officer would learn it in two weeks and would write up a finding and would file the finding against the budget line and would assign the next Korean swordsman on the procurement list.

The next round was not Kyle's problem until it was.

Tien was crying. Not screaming. He had figured out by the third kneecap that he was not going to die tonight. Not dying tonight in his current condition was striking him as worse than the alternative.

Kyle crouched.

He found the two loose teeth on the steel where Tien's face had landed. Two intact.

The third was still seated. He took it with a thumb and forefinger and a small clean turn. It came free.

Three teeth in his left hand.

IV

Behind the ventilation unit on the far wall, the breathing shifted.

Twelve. Maybe thirteen. She had been there since the threshold.

She had come down. He did not know how. He did not need to.

He walked to the unit. He did not go behind it. He stood where she could see him — a tall blood-misted shape in the dock's bad amber — and he waited.

The breathing stopped.

A face came around the corner. Her father's jaw, before the wrench. Her mother's eyes.

Kyle crouched.

The teeth lay in his palm. Two intact. The third with a hairline fracture from where he had gripped it.

There was no Carrion sticker on them. No corp manifest. No serial. No QR. No subscription number. No registry classification. No batch identifier. No barcode. No anti-counterfeit thread. No optical hologram. No royalty markup.

Just three teeth, warm.

"Present these to your father. I think he will appreciate the gesture."

She looked at the teeth. Then at him. Then at the teeth.

She held out her hands. Cupped.

He poured them in.

She did not drop them.

She shrieked, high and thin, off every hard surface in the dock and back.
She did not drop them. Her fingers closed.

She looked at her closed hands.

She looked at him.

She bowed. Full. From the waist. Two seconds. Hands cupped at her chest
the whole time.

Then she was gone.

He cleaned the blade. The tremor started in his right hand at the four-minute
mark and went briefly bilateral. The array's invoice.

He walked back to the bike.

The bike started on the first turn. He swapped the plate two blocks short of
the Wicker boundary and continued north on a different fiction.

V

Chen's stall was two blocks south of the freight tier. The hood lamp was visible through the rain from a block away.

He walked the bike the last block.

She was at the counter. Service apron. The kitchen apron was at home. The home apron, navy blue, was at home in a drawer she kept for it. He retroactively confirmed the existence of the third apron and did not pursue the thought.

She did not greet him. She set a bowl down.

Pork bone broth. Fourteen-hour. The stockpot at the back of the stall was a 1987 Foshan thirty-quart that had outlasted her two husbands and three cities. The pot, like the freight elevator, was the only thing in the building that worked. No Carrion sticker on the pot. No Hyacinth registry. No Arcturus subscription. No Helix calibration certificate. The pot did its work without filing.

Chili oil was already in the bowl. The way she would remember he liked it for the next four years.

Three quick ladle dips. First skim. Second stir. Third draw. The third was the one she poured.

He sat.

He did not sit anywhere else. At Mrs. Chen's he sat. Not because she offered. Because she had offered.

He ate the bowl. He did not speak.

She did not refill it. She did not move.

When he set the chopsticks down she was still standing where she had been.

She had more to give. She was finding the language for it.

Mh̄gōi. Low. Cantonese.

Then: "Free. Always. For you. Forever."

Her hands were flat on the counter. Her scarred thumb was the closest thing to him on the wood.

He reached into his coat and set a credit chip on the counter beside her hand. Standard rate.

"I pay. Every bowl. Standard rate. Every time."

She did not pick up the chip. He did not pick up the bowl. Four seconds.

"You took the contract at half. You did the work whole. The bowl is nothing. Forever is nothing."

He did not move the chip.

"If I do not pay, I do not eat. If I do not eat here, I do not eat. I would rather pay you than not see you again. The chip stays."

Five seconds.

Her hand closed over the chip the way her daughter's hand had closed over the teeth.

She bowed. The bow she would give him every night for the next four years. The bow of a vendor accepting a price.

He bowed back, smaller — the bow of a man who had successfully refused a kindness larger than he could carry.

"Tomorrow. Same bowl. Same price."

"Same price."

The agreement was the contract. The contract was the bond.

He turned and walked the bike out of the lamp circle.

The rain had not stopped.

The towers leaned in the way they did this far down. Above the gap an Arcturus advertising drone was projecting THE FUTURE THAT WORKS FOR YOU on the side of a residential tower whose lower three floors had been condemned eighteen months ago and had not been demolished because the demolition was on a Hyacinth schedule and the Hyacinth schedule was full. The lower three floors had people in them. The people had not been on any registry since 2222.

He laughed.

A single tight exhalation. The kind of laugh you laughed when the alternative was the alternative.

He had walked into a room of six men who would have killed an ordinary person for trying it, and he had walked out, and he had refused free noodles from a woman whose entire life he had just rearranged, and he was doing it because honor was a discipline and the discipline did not bend for noodles, and any reasonable observer would have concluded he had lost his mind.

He had not.

He was the exception to the rule.

The rule said a man performing samurai discipline in 2226 would be killed for it inside a year. The rule was correct about almost everybody. It was not correct about him. The city had built counters for many things. The corporations had paid for most of them. They had not yet decided he was the kind of problem worth paying for.

He was going to die at some point.

In the meantime, the noodles had been the right temperature, the chip had stayed on the counter, and the rain was warm at this tier.

He laughed once more, smaller. He rode home.

VI

Somebody had been watching the dock.

A camera. Second floor of the building across the alley. A panel of plywood replaced with a panel that looked like the rest but was not. The feed ran on a private channel that did not touch the Carrion grid. Carrion did not know the camera was there.

The watcher was a woman named Hira Volkova. Forty-two. Tea, not coffee, because coffee shook her hands. A bowl of dried apricots she did not like but ate because they were quiet.

Her salary cleared through four shell companies routed through a Helix subsidiary whose only employee was a man in Singapore who had not been to the office in six years. She did not know who, ultimately, signed her check. She had stopped asking in her seventh year.

She watched the walk back to the bike. She noted the pace. She noted that Kyle's hand did not move toward the saya. She noted that the breathing telemetry her organization had access to on infrastructure that did not officially exist stayed at the rest cycle.

She noted the cut to the chrome-arm man's shoulder seam. No flare. No arc. The blade had found a gap. She wrote this down. Her organization paid for correct reports. Correct reports lowered the risk premium. Lower risk premiums got passed up the chain to people who appreciated lower risk premiums.

She noted one thing she did not write down.

On a microphone better than anyone on the dock had known was there, Kyle had muttered a phrase between the wrist falling and the blade going back in the saya. Three syllables. Not in any language Kyle spoke. She ran it against eleven candidate corpora. Eighty-one-percent match to a sub-

variant of Tocharian B that had not been adequately preserved in any extant corpus.

Approximate translation: *we have him now.*

She did not put it in the report.

She filed it on the encrypted side of her personal log, on a directory she had not touched in three years.

The things you filed separately were the things that turned out to be the answer.

The report would be reviewed two months later by Hua, south-arm cell captain of the Lotus Syndicate. Hua would close the file and pass it to her gang lieutenant Mira with a second file labelled *Bucktown — first interview — fourteen-piece.*

The Tocharian was not in the report Hua read.

It would not surface for some time.

Kyle rode home.

The noodles would be cold by morning. They always were.

The hum in his chest was at 19Hz, the frequency a NeoCortex Atlas research grade had been broadcasting since the boy from the Grind had been sixteen, and the boy from the Grind did not yet know who else was tuned to that frequency, and the people who had tuned them both did not have to know either.

That was the trick.

The trick was that nobody who built the city had to know the city anymore.

The trick was that the trail led upstream and the upstream had been engineered, by people whose names were on contracts the public could not

read, to lead nowhere a working person could reach.

That was the work of years.

Tonight was the work of one night.

Tonight, the work was done.

Hira put another apricot in her mouth. She chewed it without enthusiasm. She watched the bike's running light fade north into the rain.

The city continued.

The corporations continued.

The trail continued upstream.

The teeth in the daughter's cupped hands continued home.

That was the only thing on the cross-street tonight that did not have a sticker on it.

She was twelve.

She would remember.